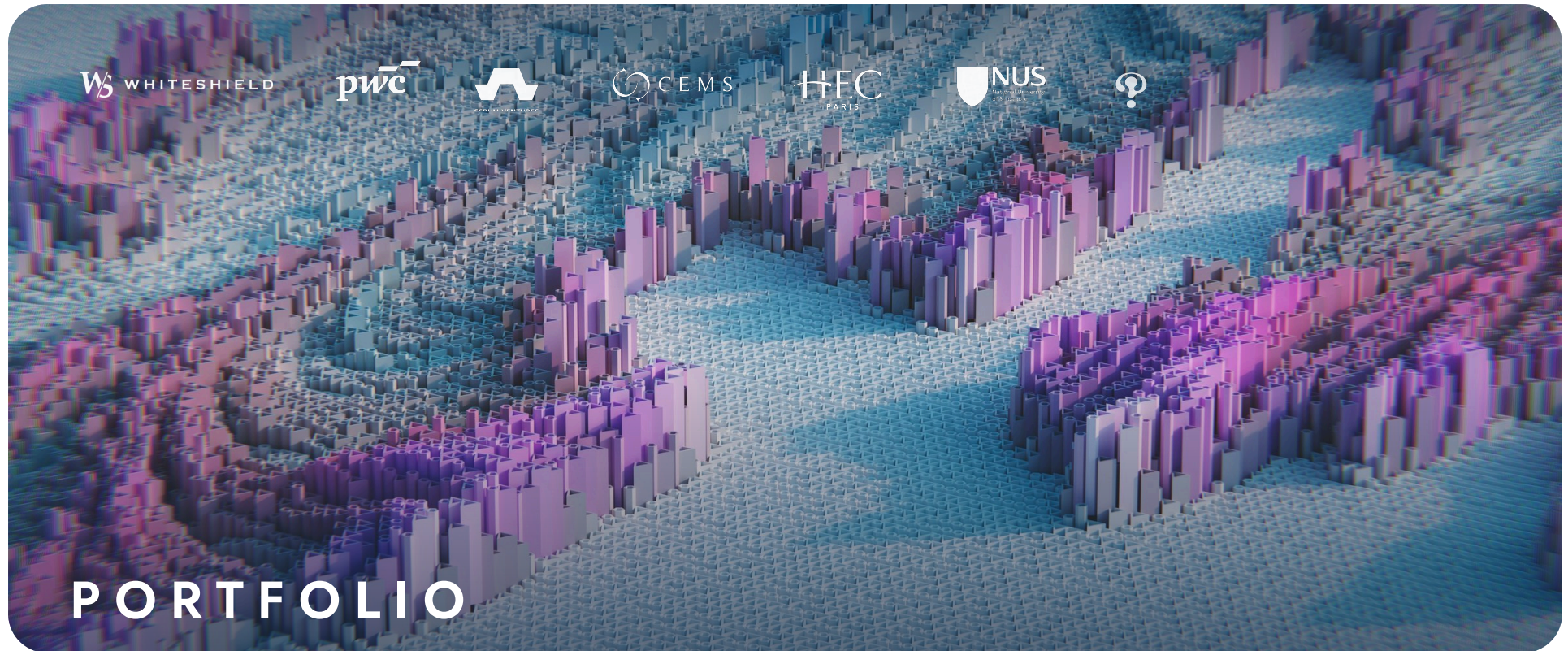




ARATA HOSHINO

SELECTED WORKS IN STRATEGIC DESIGN & VENTURE DESIGN | GCC · NORTHEAST ASIA · US



TECHNOLOGY x DESIGN x SOVEREIGN-SCALE PROJECTS

BACKGROUND

2016 - 2020

Understand technology itself.

I studied Mechanical & Energy Engineering at Waseda University: thermodynamics, energy R&D, robotics, urban mobility, satellite design, and nuclear engineering; close to the realm of Physical AI today.

2020 - 2023

Translate technology into societal change.

I earned two master's degrees: at Keio Media Design (Japan's equivalent of MIT Media Lab), I researched and practiced Service Design methodology (Dean's Award); and a CEMS Master's at HEC Paris and the National University of Singapore, bridging concept and commercialization.

2023 -

Choose the side of execution.

I joined the Singapore headquarters of a global strategy consultancy, working on physical mega-projects such as EV gigafactory siting for a global auto-OEM. Seeking work at sovereign scale, I then moved to the UAE, advancing projects alongside ministry stakeholders at an OECD-rooted economic advisory firm.

METHODS

1. DESIGN RESEARCH

Double diamond process · Ethnographic research · Workshops · Personas to journeys · User stories

2. PROTOTYPING & VALIDATION

Design direction · AI-automated lo-fi prototyping and its review · AI-augmented workflow · PoC & validation

3. IMPLEMENTATION

Product management · Sprint management · Product validation · Engineering collaboration · Venture design

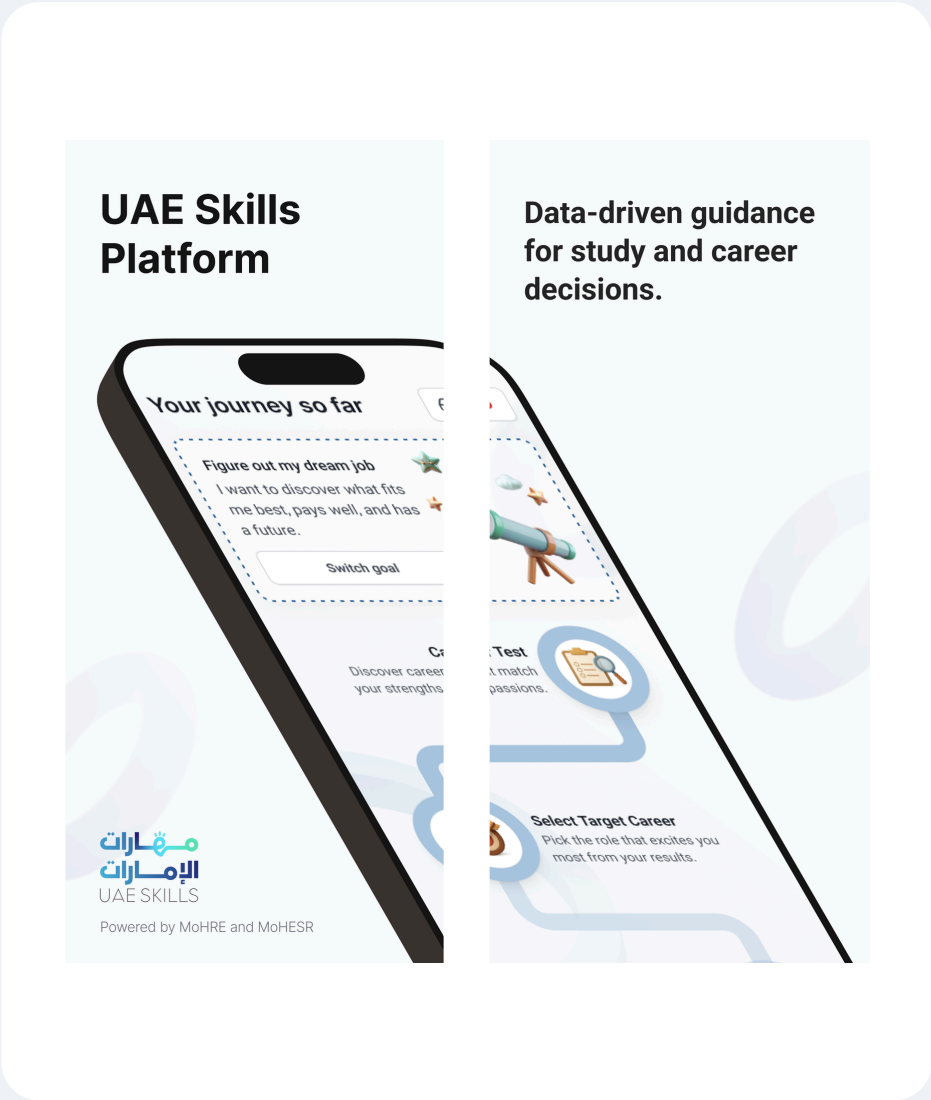
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02	Branch & ATM Network Platform · the UAE’s largest bank AI siting recommendations that C-suite relocation and site-selection decisions rest on	Service designer & product owner: discovery workshops, IA, personas & journeys, wireframes	09
03	SME Procurement Platform · Abu Dhabi government entity Procurement platform routing corporate and government spend to local SMEs	Service designer: contextual inquiry, personas & journeys, lo-fi wireframes, BR/FR backlog	12
04	Service Design for Consultants · PwC Cybersecurity × CSIRT Collaborative design research with PwC; visualizing client values and mental models	Solo researcher & designer: ethnography under NDA, handbook system, two-cycle PoC	15
05	Service Design at Tokyo International Airport Enhancing the experience of exploring airport facilities during waiting time	Researcher & service designer: ethnography (100+ observed), persona, service blueprint, UI flows	18
	Other related works Case 6 - 9 · Homecoming Garden · Takizme · Gucci for the Future · Career Design Studio	Service design, product design, AI-driven experience strategy, and ecosystem facilitation	21

UAE Skills: A national AI platform connecting education, skills, and the labor market

A national platform built for two UAE federal ministries: Human Resources & Emiratization, and Higher Education & Scientific Research. On the government side, policy makers get labor-market intelligence, forecasting, and program benchmarking. On the citizen side, students see which occupations are growing and which degrees lead to them.

CLIENT	UAE MoHRE × UAE MoHESR
ROLE	Product owner, citizen-facing interfaces
SCOPE	Personas · journeys · backlog · QA
PERIOD	Jul 2025 - Mar 2026
OUTCOME	National launch · 20,000 users



CONTEXT

UAE Skills transforms both national workforce planning and the way a single student chooses a degree.

The UAE planned its education system and its labor market from separate data. That gap matters more now: AI is changing which skills employers need faster than curricula can follow, and no one could see the demand side and the supply side at the same time.

The platform merges the two into one model, then gives each audience its own interface; nine in all. My contribution was the citizen side: the four interfaces the public uses, plus the pre-login landing page.

WHAT GOES IN

Labor market data

The demand side: which skills employers are asking for, and how fast that is moving as AI reshapes the work

Education data

The supply side: how many students graduate each year, and with which skills

ONE MODEL

UAE Skills

One national database that links every occupation to the skills it needs and to the programs that teach them, refreshed each month against real job postings

WHO DECIDES WITH IT

Government

An AI-built visualization of supply against demand, read for policy decisions

Citizens

AI recommendations on the field of study and occupation, matched to market trends and their own interests

MY WORKSTREAM

RESEARCH & PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

Students arrive with different goals, so the goal itself became the entry point: three buttons, each starting the journey at a different step.

PERSONA EXAMPLES



Fatima 21, Dubai
Curious, overwhelmed, often unsure
"I don't really know what jobs are out there, or what suits me."

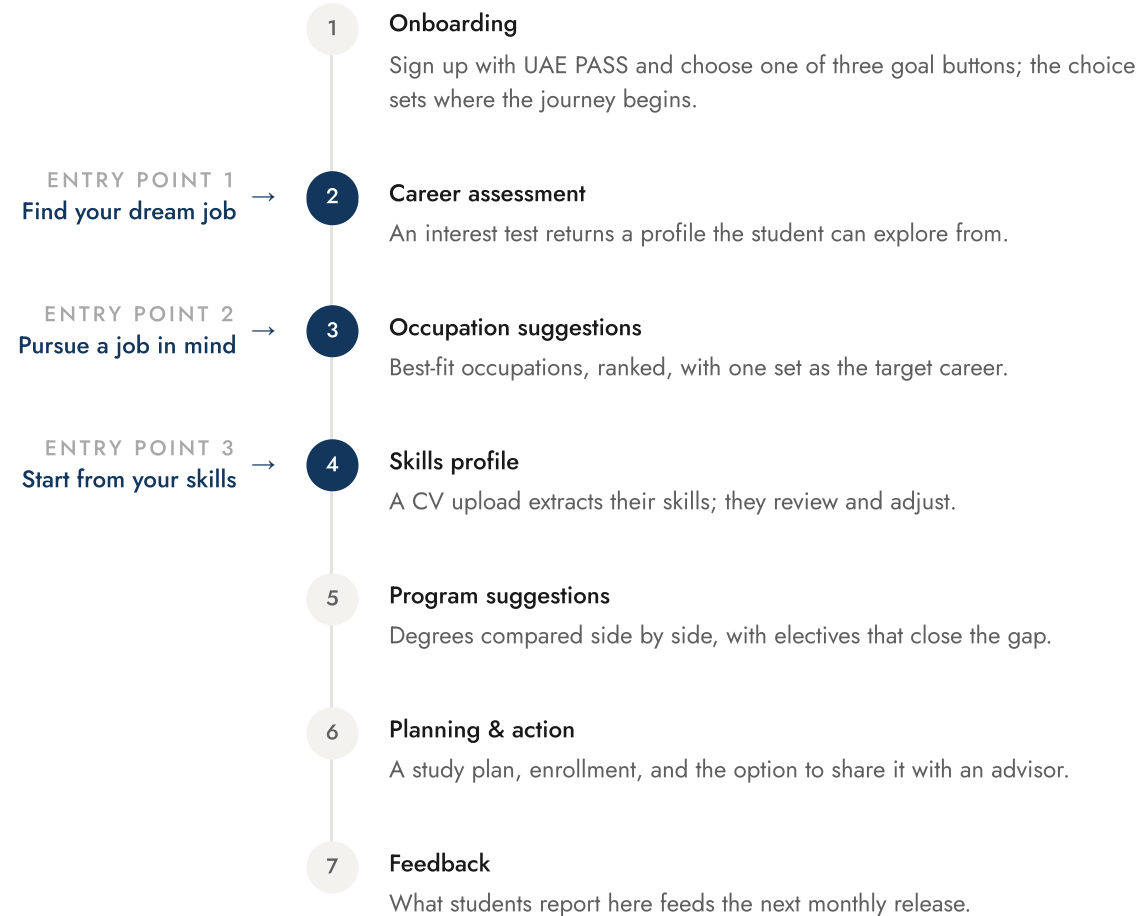


Maryam 23, Ras Al Khaimah
Strategic, data-driven, cautious
"I want to know which job matches my skills today, and what steps close the gaps."



Ahmed 24, Sharjah
Focused, goal-driven, prefers certainty
"I know what job I want after graduation, but I'm not sure if I'm ready for it."

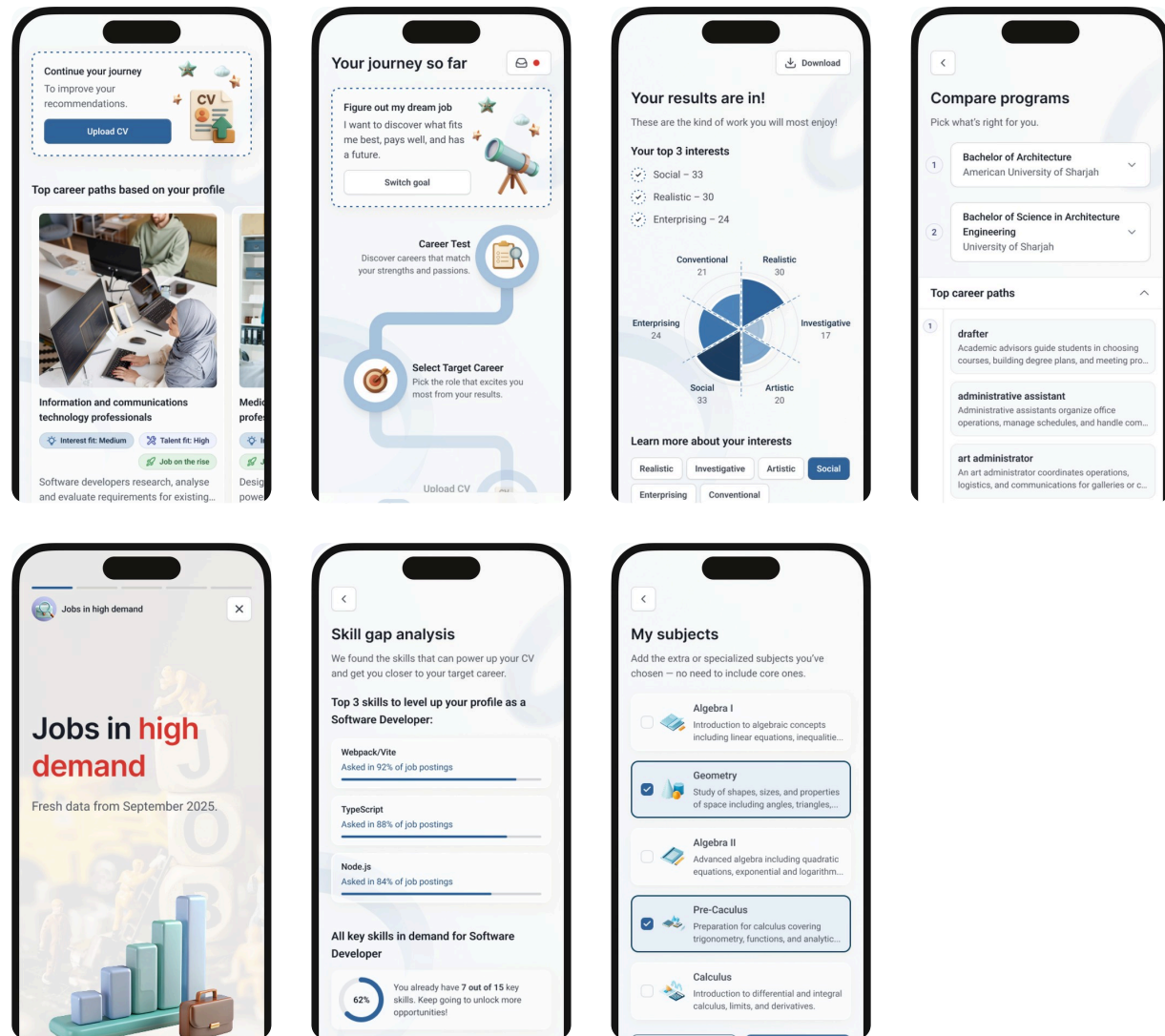
JOURNEY EXAMPLE · THREE GOALS, THREE ENTRY POINTS



PROTOTYPE

As product owner on the citizen side, my contribution spanned from requirements, personas and journeys, and user stories, through ideation and lo-fi mockups, to design direction and QA to launch.

I drew the lo-fi screens in Figma alongside a UI specialist, who then produced the hi-fi mockups; I reviewed each iteration with the team against the user stories, and set the design direction until launch.



IMPACT

Built to cover 1.2 million students in the UAE, the platform reached about 20,000 users after launch and now informs policy at both ministries.



Ministries

Labor-market and education data now sit in one place. Supply-demand gaps and forecasts replace manual reporting, so policy can respond while the signal is still current.

Universities and schools

Institutions can benchmark their own programs against employer demand, and counselors can see what their students are actually choosing.

Citizens

Free and public, in English and Arabic. A student can test their interests, upload a CV, see the gap to a target job, and compare the degrees that close it.

Branch & ATM Network Platform: AI recommendations the C-suite can decide site selection and relocation on

A planning tool that tells a bank where to open its next branch or ATM, and which existing sites to move. It scores every candidate location in the country on demand, competition, and access, then has an AI layer check the top candidates against satellite imagery.

CLIENT	The largest bank in the UAE (anonymized under NDA)
ROLE	Service designer & product owner
SCOPE	Personas · journeys · geospatial ground truth
PERIOD	Mar - Sep 2026
OUTCOME	Live UAE nationwide · 361,435 areas/run



Simulation loading screen (screen withheld under NDA)

RESEARCH & PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

Two personas at the bank, the executive who decides and the analyst who defends; each got a journey, and every feature was ideated and mapped onto the step it serves.

PERSONA EXAMPLES

Executive user

Leads location decisions across 10-15 branches

Location calls are rare, so know-how never accumulates.

Operational user

Analyst on the physical locations team

Fragmented data eats the time before any judgment starts.

JOURNEY EXAMPLES · THE FEELING EACH STEP HAS TO EARN

Executive

- 1 Initialize scenario
confidence
- 2 Calibrate dimensions
empowerment
- 3 Review recommendations
insight
- 4 Select and analyze
clarity
- 5 Iterate scenarios
robustness

Operational

- 1 Initialize scenario
orientation
- 2 Calibrate control panel
control
- 3 Verify against heatmaps
confidence
- 4 Analyze and export
thoroughness
- 5 Iterate scenarios
foresight
- 6 Consolidate and report
completion

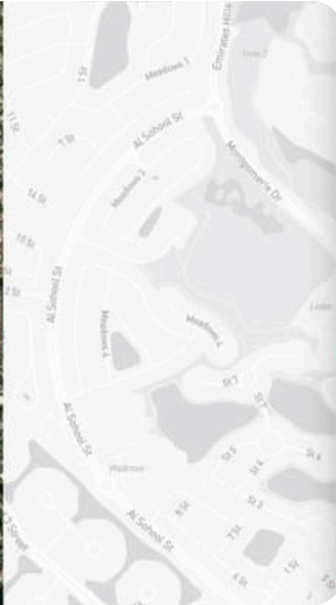
PROTOTYPE

The planner sets the weights on the left, the map carries the evidence, and the model returns ranked candidates on the right.

INPUT PANEL

Scenario setup and driver weights: branch or ATM, new site or relocation, search area, then the four families of drivers normalized to 100 percent.

** Screen masked: client-confidential*



OUTPUT PANEL

Ranked candidates from the simulation: site, confidence, and the model's rationale.

#1

#2

...

** Screen masked: client-confidential*

THE GROUND TRUTH COMPILED FOR THE MODEL

95 malls, all seven emirates

Every coordinate hand-verified, every site boundary digitized as a polygon, tier and audience profiled per mall

Mega-project pipeline

Major developments with catchment radii; station lists for four planned rail and metro networks, unannounced stations flagged as proxies

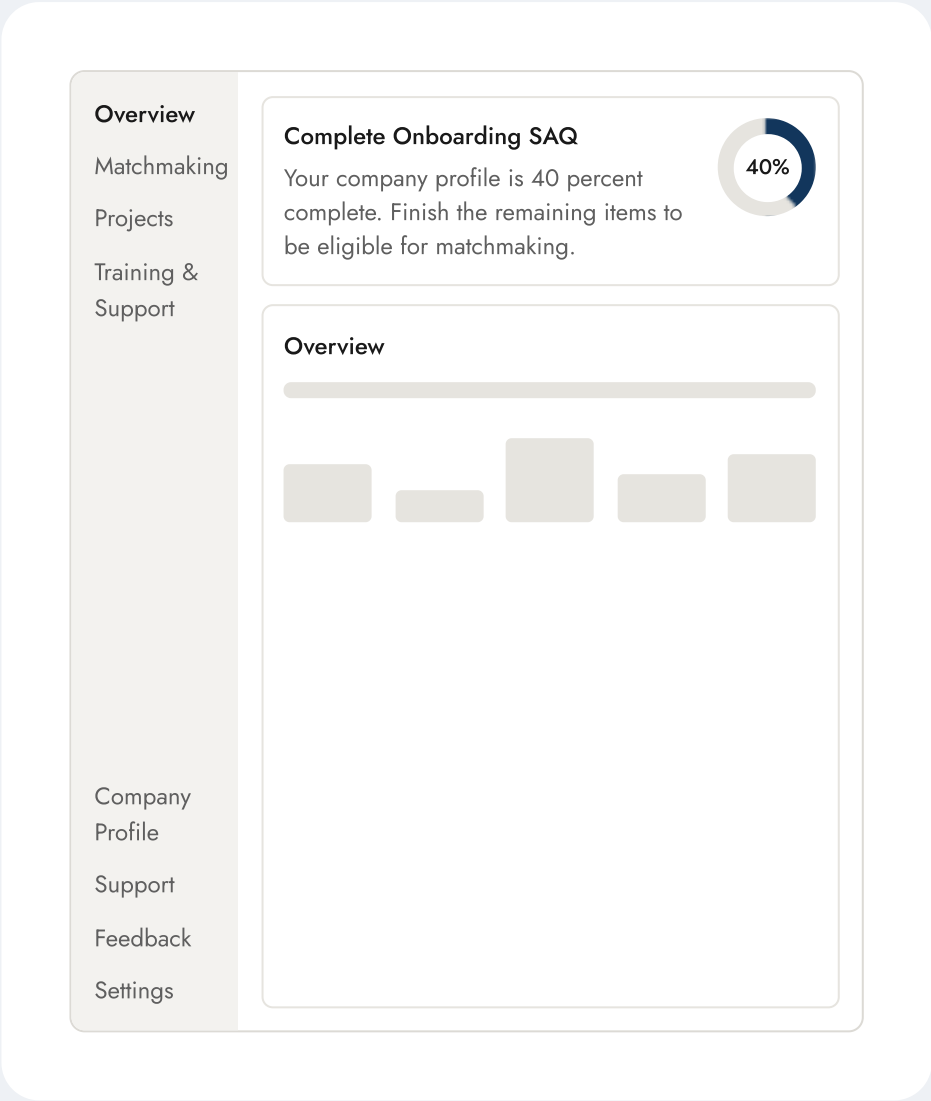
Radius conventions

500 m for metro, 1 km for intercity rail: how far a customer will actually walk

SME Champions: More opportunity for Abu Dhabi’s SMEs, and more national spend staying local

A government platform connecting Abu Dhabi’s small businesses with large corporate and government buyers: register, train to meet buyer standards, get matched to open demand, and transact, all in one system. The goal is national. More opportunity for SMEs, more local sourcing by large buyers, and more of the country’s spend circulating at home.

CLIENT	Abu Dhabi government entity (anonymized under NDA)
ROLE	Service designer, delivery team
SCOPE	Personas · journeys · mockups · BR/FR
PERIOD	May - Dec 2024
OUTCOME	Approved by four stakeholders · moved to build



SME dashboard, redrawn

DESIGN RESEARCH & JOURNEY MAPPING

Contextual inquiry with every actor in the pipeline surfaced the pain points behind six personas.

WORKSHOPS & CONTEXTUAL INQUIRY

Seven input sources across three stakeholder groups: client workshops and the SME register, 15 buyer interviews and surveys, and interviews with training and support providers.

PERSONA EXAMPLES · RECONSTRUCTED

Aspiring Enterprise

Small SME, under two years in the market, not yet tech-ready
Cannot find opportunities, and does not know how to bid.

Enterprise Enabler

Large private buyer, procuring locally to lift its ICV score
Eligible SMEs never appear in its tenders.

SME JOURNEY · THE PAIN EACH STEP HAD TO REMOVE

- 1 **Registration and onboarding**
Register and complete the self-assessment.
Pain: fails the assessment; review takes time.
- 2 **View and edit profile**
Keep the profile current; matchmaking reads from it.
Pain: every edit needs e-mailed approval.
- 3 **Upskilling and support**
Train up to the matching criteria.
Pain: no resources to find the right training.
- 4 **Matchmaking**
Receive buyer interest and bid.
Pain: no staff to hunt, no bidding know-how.
- 5 **Project delivery**
Deliver under contract.
Pain: capacity and financing threaten deadlines.

WIREFRAMES & POC

Journeys became 114 BRs and 355 FRs, each traceable to a screen; lo-fi wireframes carried the PoC.

ONE CHAIN PER REQUIREMENT



FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS · TWO EXAMPLES OF 355

FR ID	REQUIREMENT
FR-009-03	Automated scoring of SME self-assessment responses
FR-020-08	SMEs ranked by their matching score
⋮	

* Wording paraphrased; screens withheld as client-confidential.

A PoC workshop walked the client and the engineering consortium through the wireframes screen by screen. Four stakeholder entities approved the package and it moved into build.

Founding buyers gave matchmaking real demand from day one. Post-launch metrics sit with the client.

DELIVERED PACKAGE



THE SCALE IT ADDRESSES · PUBLIC ESTIMATES



PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

Whether a client acts on security metrics depends on how well the consultant has read the organization: its values, its internal politics, and how it handled past incidents. That reading stayed tacit.

01 · INTERVIEW

Participant observation was impossible under NDA, so ethnographic research was conducted built on staged interviews with three stakeholder groups.

PwC consultants

A director working across multiple projects, and the manager on the security-metrics service

Client side

Security specialist and the founder of a private university's CSIRT

Field-wide view

Independent researcher with visibility across ~500 member organizations of the national CSIRT association

02 · ISSUES IDENTIFIED

How might we make explicit the way a consultant reads a client's values and internal politics, so that the reading can be taught rather than intuited?

- 01 Clients act on metrics that fit their values, politics and incident history, not on correct ones.
- 02 Consultants read that by intuition, so it stays with the individual and cannot scale.
- 03 Clients see no reason to explain their values, and expect an answer in one exchange.

03 · GOALS AND MENTAL MODELS EXTRACTED

Consultant

- GOAL To be trusted not to walk away, and to build what the company needs, not one person's ask.
- MENTAL MODEL When a client stalls over the effort, step back and find another person inside who can move it.

Client · governance line

- GOAL Strengthen the organization long term at the lowest cost, and be told where to start.
- MENTAL MODEL Reads a call to strengthen security as cost; moves only when shown metrics outside its current view.

Client · first line

- GOAL Keep the network as open as the campus expects, and still close incidents quickly.
- MENTAL MODEL Stops an error reported from outside at once; handles the same error at its own pace when found internally.

Service design at Tokyo International Airport: Enhancing the experience of exploring airport facilities during waiting time

Departure boards show a boarding time, not the time remaining, so passengers clear security and wait at the gate; the commercial area the airport has invested in stays underused. The design moves that calculation onto the luggage cart: time to the gate, the latest time to leave, and what is worth stopping for nearby.

PARTNER	Japan Airport Terminal Co., Ltd.
ROLE	Researcher & service designer
METHODS	Participant observation · persona & scenario · UI flows
PERIOD	Feb - Aug 2021
OUTCOME	Service blueprint · low-fidelity prototype



Low-fidelity prototype · cart-mounted display

PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

Passengers do not skip the shops for lack of interest. They skip them because leaving the route and coming back in time is a risk they cannot size.

01 · PARTICIPANT OBSERVATION

I ran participant observation over a month, covering the landside area before the security gate and the international airside commercial area, then analyzed the ethnography.

100+

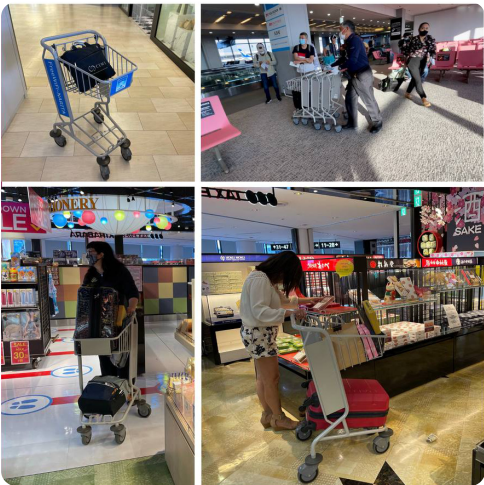
28

57

observed

thick descriptions

mental models



02 · WHAT BLOCKS STROLLING

- 01
- The terminal is one-way traffic. Passengers find it hard to retrace their steps to the gate or leave the main route at all.
- 02
- They are still carrying cabin bags after check-in, so every detour costs effort.
- 03
- No one tells them how long each checkpoint takes, so they buy certainty by going to the gate early and staying there.

"In an unfamiliar airport I go early to the gate, where it is easy to gather information about my flight, and I end up spending a lot of time there."

— Interviewee, entrepreneur

03 · WHY AN APP DOES NOT SOLVE IT

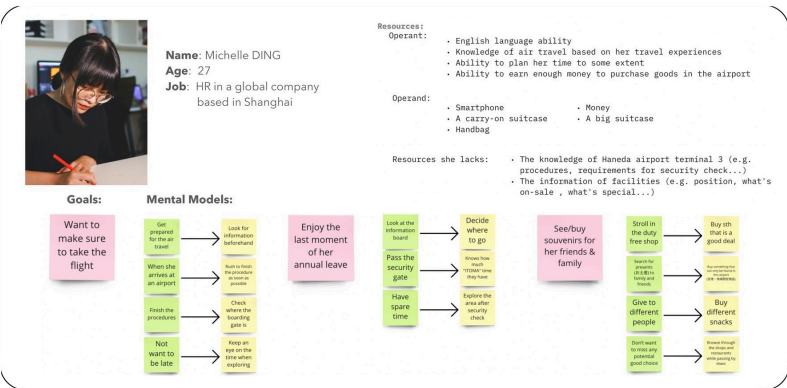
- I reviewed the Haneda app, two airline apps and four top-rated airport apps. None joined access, flight and shopping information; the best stopped at waiting times.
- 01
- They are built to organize documents and shorten time in the airport, not to support the shopping experience.
- 02
- Installing one is a barrier for a passenger who flies through this airport once every few years.
- 03
- Using one means stopping to look at a phone, which works against the movement it is meant to support.

CONCEPT & SERVICE DESIGN

The information belongs on the luggage cart rather than in an app, because the passenger’s hands are already on it.

PERSONA AND THE VALUE PROPOSED

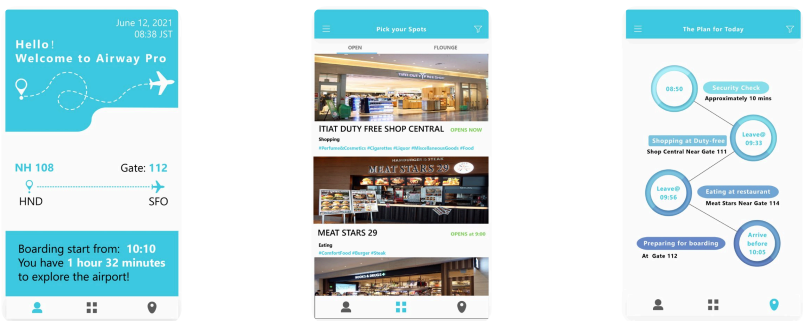
Persona built from the fieldwork: the goal is to explore within the time available; the pain is not knowing how long the procedures ahead will take.



- 01 **Comfort:** the wait turns into a plan she can see and spend
- 02 **Curiosity:** shops and souvenirs surface along her route, not off it
- 03 **Satisfaction:** the last hours in the country are spent shopping, and still at the gate on time

WHAT THE SCREEN HAS TO CARRY

A plan generated from flight data, walking and waiting times, and nearby stores. Cart pools land-side and air-side carry the plan across the security gate.



RELATED WORKS

CASE 06



Homecoming Garden

Aug 2020 - Feb 2021 · Concept design · Society for Serviceology, 2021

Concept design for the arrival corridor at Tokyo International Airport: an interactive Japanese garden reconstructed for the senses, combining projection, sound and scent. The PoC confirmed the calming value but refuted the core hypothesis, so the value proposition was rewritten to what the evidence supported.

CASE 07

Takizme · [instagram.com/takizme](https://www.instagram.com/takizme)

Sep 2018 - Feb 2020 · Venture design · Prototyping · Service design

Venture design for a Japanese tea experience reinterpreted for the present. Co-built the business model, positioning and brand vision, and facilitated product ideation and prototyping around one idea: a pit stop for people with no time to stop.

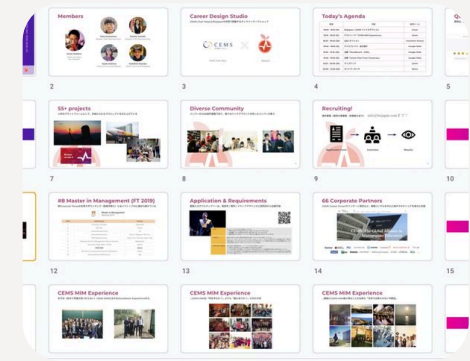
CASE 08

Gucci for the Future · [watch the film](#)

Sep - Nov 2021 · AI-driven experience concept · HEC Paris (CEMS MIM)

An AI-driven experience strategy for the future of luxury, argued as a concept film: five moves (personalization, localization, virtualization, experience-orientation, channel diversification), closing with machine-generated designs as the provocation.

CASE 09



Career Design Studio

Aug - Dec 2020 · Workshop & ecosystem design · CEMS Club Tokyo × Bizjapan

Designed and ran a 35-participant career-visioning workshop, and the ecosystem around it: a student task force, partnership incentives, and moodboard-to-ideal-CV worksheets that made 2030 tangible.

THANK YOU FOR READING

Strategic and venture designer with an engineering background, applying service design methods to AI products at sovereign scale.

Recent projects: career recommendations for citizens on a national platform, AI site-selection recommendations used by a bank’s executives, and AI matchmaking between SMEs and large buyers. On each I covered interviews and workshops, personas and journeys, user stories, lo-fi prototypes in Figma, design direction, and QA, working with engineers and data scientists.

I use AI in the design process as well: lo-fi prototyping, requirement drafting, and review.

** Client names and materials under confidentiality are withheld or reconstructed throughout this portfolio. Each project can be discussed as far as confidentiality allows.*

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